

CoolPix 885 and the Camedia 3020. Since these cameras offer far superior capabilities and performance, it would be unfair to compare them with the rest of the cameras in this category. Hence, we reviewed them separately. Besides, there aren't many such cameras available in the Indian market.

Test methodology

We evaluated the cameras on the following parameters:

Features: Here we awarded points depending on the various features and capabilities of the camera, such as CCD resolution, maximum image resolution supported, optical and digital zoom, focussing types, metering modes, white balance implementation, flash modes, shutter speed, storage, battery type, video-out capabilities, etc.

The camera's features were allotted a 30 per cent weightage.

Performance: We tested the camera's CCD's ability to correctly reproduce colour and capture details. To do this, we created a test scene that was used as the target for all the cameras. The lighting in this scene was kept constant for all cameras. We shot this scene by mounting the camera on a tripod and chose the highest possible resolution setting that was supported by it. We used the camera's flash to shoot the scene and all other settings such as white balance, metering and flash modes were kept at their factory default.

The target scene comprised of a shot of a desktop (refer to the test image) where we introduced elements such as a wide tonal range (flowers of different colours), gradation in shading, specular highlights brought out through shiny metallic objects (the spectacles, binder and flower vase) and plenty of details (as in the lace curtain and tablecloth, the text on the stack of books, the grains in the clay of the vase). We graded each of the cameras for the level of accuracy with which each of these aspects of the image were captured.

After shooting the scene, we analysed the image at its

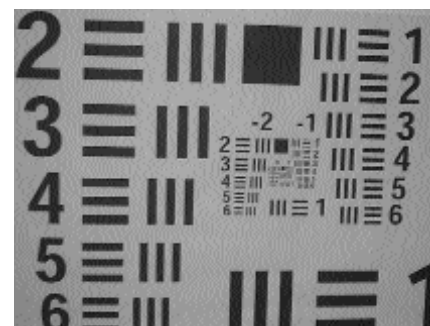
actual pixel size in Photoshop 6 using the Histogram function. This is a powerful tool that lets you analyse the level of the Red, Green, Blue and Luminosity (brightness) components in an image. With this, we logged the standard deviation that was displayed for each of these channels from a reference value. We studied the images from all cameras and the one that was the most accurate representation of the test scene was used to obtain the reference values. We then measured the standard deviation to ascertain by how much over (or under) the remainder images deviated from this optimal reference value. This test measures the accuracy of the CCD when it comes to sensing colour and brightness.

The second imaging test measured the resolution of the CCD by shooting a resolution chart, which consisted of vertical and horizontal bars of gradually decreasing sizes. We took a photograph of this chart from 1 metre away and logged how many bars could be seen in the resulting image at its actual pixel size in Photoshop.

The weightage allotted to the camera's overall performance was 30 per cent.

Ergonomics: We logged various aspects of the camera's construction and the inclusion of features that enhance its ease of use. This comprised of aspects such as how comfortable it was to hold, the ease with which the menu could be

navigated, the size of the buttons and the inclusion of special menu navigation buttons. Since these cameras are meant



The resolution chart

to be used outdoor very frequently, protection is very important. Hence, we looked at features such as the inclusion of a lens cover, a wrist band for preventing damage by dropping and special construction that offers water and dust resistance.

The size and weight of a digital camera are also pertinent matters to consider while choosing the right one. You'll probably be carrying the camera in your shirt pocket or handbag while travelling and you don't want to be weighed down by an ungainly device.

This category was allotted a weightage of 10 per cent.

Warranty and support: Here we took into account the warranty period for the digital cameras, the number of authorised service centres appointed by the companies and the number of cities in which authorised service centres are available. The information here is as provided by the respective companies.

The weightage for this category was 10 per cent.

Value for money: This is a factor of the performance and features offered by the camera as compared to its price. Therefore, the greater the performance and features and the lower the price, the higher will be the value for money offered by a camera. We computed this value by dividing the sum of a camera's performance and features by its price to obtain a value-for-money index.

The weightage allotted to this category was 20 per cent. →

